

THE IPL'S SOCIAL WHIRL: (FROM LEFT) KUNDRA AND SHETTY, MUKESH AMBANI WITH WIFE NITA AND DAUGHTER ISHA, SIDDHARTH MALLYA, MODI WITH VJAY MALLYA (TOP) AND DECCAN CHARGERS' DUO GAYATRI AND VENKATRAM REDDY

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have absolutely no interest in cricket," consortium member Mukul Patel was quoted in a newspaper. Patel and partner Vipul Shah own Gujarat-based Shree Ram Group of Industries, which is in the ship-recycling business. To him and the rest of the Kochi franchise called Rendezvous Sports World, led by Shailendra Gaikwad and Pooja Gulati; Dilip Mehta, owner of Rosy Blue Diamond and jewellery brand Orra; and Mehul Shah of Gujarat-based Anchor Switches, the IPL is the first step into cricket's IP-El Dorado.

What awaits them are finding revenue streams to flood the franchise coffers and a diplomatic maze that is the multi-owner group. Yes, the valuations do receive a real boost. When British businessman Raj Kundra bought 12 per cent equity in Emerging Media for \$15 million, it raised the price of the Rajasthan Royals team from \$67 million to \$140 million. But many owners are like multiple captains. Kings XI Punjab are the best example:

this week one of its joint owners Mohit Burman said the team would be sold if they were offered more than \$250 million. In quick response, the Wadia group speaking for another joint Kings XI owner Ness Wadia, said talk of a sale was "not correct". Obviously, in both fact and conduct.

Despite the IPL's glitz-blitz, cricket's defenders, and they do still exist, continue to think of it as Evil Incarnate and Modi as Chief Priest. Or at least its Gordon Gekko of the 'greed is good' school of business. What cannot be wished away is the IPL's popularity and Modi's ability to coast over any failures—be it the failure of the theatrical screenings to take off or obsequious commentators. Modi ignores all criticism, excited at the idea of running the semi-finals and final in 3-D, at double the ticket price.

The IPL has been Modi's making. Globally, he is now India's best known

sports official (Suresh Kalmadi, eat your heart out) sought after by media from San Francisco to Sydney. From his 1992 entry into the world of business to a stuttering tie-up TV deal with ESPN, he was one of the least successful scions of a Modi empire involved in metal, healthcare, real estate and tobacco (Godfrey Philips remains his baby). Ever since the IPL bloomed in 2008, though, he is now the family's most-noticed and best-known son.

He has spent a decade trying to enter the BCCI via Mumbai, Punjab and then Rajasthan. He then allied himself to the Sharad Pawar-led faction that sought to oust the then BCCI monarch Jagmohan Dalmiya and became its irreverent face. He had once paced up and down in his Worli office, kicking the air and angrily asking a journalist, "BCCI kisi ki jaagir hai kya?" (Is the BCCI anyone's property?). Today, many believe Modi has made it his own.

The success of IPL Season 1 was the honeymoon phase, Season 2 a bold ex-